

World War II

World War II,^[b] or the **Second World War** (1 September 1939 – 2 September 1945), was a global conflict between two coalitions: the Allies and the Axis powers. Nearly all of the world's countries participated. Tanks and aircraft played major roles, the latter enabling the strategic bombing of cities and delivery of the only nuclear weapons used in war. World War II was the deadliest conflict in history, causing the death of 60 to 75 million people. Millions died as a result of massacres, starvation, disease, and genocides, including the Holocaust. After the Allied victory, Germany, Austria, Japan, and Korea were occupied, and German and Japanese leaders were tried for war crimes.

The causes of World War II included unresolved tensions in the aftermath of World War I and the rise of fascism in Europe and militarism in Japan. Key events preceding the war included Japan's invasion of Manchuria in 1931, the Spanish Civil War, the outbreak of the Second Sino-Japanese War in 1937, and Germany's annexations of Austria and the Sudetenland. World War II is generally considered to have begun on 1 September 1939, when Nazi Germany, under Adolf Hitler, invaded Poland, after which the United Kingdom and France declared war on Germany. Poland was also invaded by the Soviet Union in mid-September and was partitioned between Germany and the Soviet Union under the Molotov–Ribbentrop Pact.

World War II



From top to bottom, left to right:

German Stuka dive bombers on the Eastern Front, 1943 · British Matilda II tanks during the North African campaign, 1941 · US atomic bombing of Nagasaki in Japan, 1945 · Soviet troops at the Battle of Stalingrad, 1943 · Soviet soldier raising a flag over the Reichstag after the Battle of Berlin, 1945 · US warships in Lingayen Gulf in the Philippines, 1945

Date	1 September 1939 – 2 September 1945 ^[a] (6 years, 1 day)
Location	<u>Global</u>
Result	<u>Allied victory</u> (see <u>Aftermath of World War II</u>)
<u>Belligerents</u>	

In 1940, the Soviet Union annexed the Baltic states and parts of Finland and Romania, while Germany conquered Norway, Denmark, Belgium, Luxembourg, and the Netherlands. After the fall of France in June 1940, the war continued mainly between Germany, now assisted by Fascist Italy, and the British Empire and British Commonwealth, with fighting in the Balkans, Mediterranean and Middle East, East Africa, the aerial Battle of Britain and the Blitz, and the naval Battle of the Atlantic. By mid-1941, Yugoslavia and Greece had also been defeated by Axis countries. In June 1941, Germany invaded the Soviet Union, opening the Eastern Front.

Allies

Axis

Commanders and leaders

Main Allied leaders:



Joseph Stalin



Franklin D. Roosevelt



Winston Churchill



Chiang Kai-shek

Main Axis leaders:



Adolf Hitler



Hirohito



Benito Mussolini

Casualties and losses

60–75 million deaths (military and civilian)
(see World War II casualties)

In December 1941, Japan attacked American and British territories in Asia and the Pacific, including Pearl Harbor in Hawaii, leading the United States to enter the war against the Axis. Japan conquered much of coastal China and Southeast Asia, but its advances in the Pacific were halted in June 1942 at the Battle of Midway. In early 1943, Axis forces were defeated in North Africa and at Stalingrad in the Soviet Union. An Allied invasion of Italy in July resulted in the fall of its fascist regime, and Allied offensives in the Pacific and the Soviet Union forced the Axis to retreat on all fronts. In 1944, the Western Allies invaded France at Normandy, and the Soviet Union advanced into Central Europe. Japan also suffered major setbacks including the crippling of its navy by the United States, the loss of key Western Pacific islands, and defeats in Burma.

The war in Europe concluded with the liberation of German-occupied territories and the invasion of Germany by the Allies, which culminated in the fall of Berlin to Soviet troops and Germany's unconditional surrender on 8 May 1945. On 6 and 9 August, the US dropped atomic bombs on Hiroshima and Nagasaki followed by a Soviet invasion of Japanese-occupied Manchuria. Japan announced its unconditional surrender on 15 August and signed a surrender document on 2 September 1945. World War II transformed the political, economic, and social structures of the world, and established the foundation of international relations for the rest of the 20th century and into the 21st century. The United Nations was created to foster international cooperation and prevent future conflicts, with the victorious great powers—China, France, the Soviet Union, the UK, and the US—becoming the permanent members of its Security Council. The Soviet Union and the US emerged as rival superpowers, setting the stage for the Cold War. In the wake of Europe's devastation, the influence of its great powers waned, triggering the decolonisation of Africa and of Asia. Many countries whose industries had been damaged moved towards economic recovery and expansion.

Start and end dates

Most historians agree that World War II began with the German invasion of Poland on 1 September 1939 and the British and French declarations of war on Germany two days later.^[1] Dates for the beginning of the Pacific War include the start of the Second Sino-Japanese War on 7 July 1937, or the earlier Japanese invasion of Manchuria on 18 September 1931.^{[2][3][4][5]} Other proposed starting dates include the Italian invasion of Abyssinia on 3 October 1935.^[6] The British historian Antony Beevor views the beginning of World War II as the Battles of Khalkhin Gol fought between Japan and the forces of Mongolia and the Soviet Union from May to September 1939.^[7] Others view the Spanish Civil War as the start or prelude to World War II.^{[8][9]}

The date of the war's end is also not universally agreed upon. It was generally accepted at the time that the war ended with the armistice of 15 August 1945 (V-J Day), rather than with the formal surrender of Japan on 2 September 1945, which officially ended the war in Asia. A peace treaty between Japan and the Allies was signed in 1951.^[10] A 1990 treaty regarding Germany's future allowed the reunification of East and West Germany to take place.^[11] No formal peace treaty between Japan and the Soviet Union was ever signed, although the state of war between the two countries was terminated by the Soviet–Japanese Joint Declaration of 1956, which also restored full diplomatic relations between them.^{[12][13]}

Background

Aftermath of World War I

World War I radically altered the European political map. The most prominent nations of the Central Powers each lost territory in their respective peace treaties at the conclusion of the conflict. New nation-states were created out of the dissolution of the Austro-Hungarian, Ottoman, and Russian Empires.^[14]

To prevent a future world war, the League of Nations was established in 1920 by the Paris Peace Conference. The organisation's primary function was to prevent armed conflict through collective security, military, and naval disarmament, as well as settling international disputes through peaceful negotiations and arbitration.^[15]



The League of Nations assembly, held in Geneva, Switzerland (1930)

Despite strong pacifist sentiment after World War I, irredentist and revanchist nationalism had emerged in several European states.^[16] These sentiments were especially pronounced in Germany due to the significant territorial, colonial, and financial losses imposed by the Treaty of Versailles. Under the treaty, Germany lost around 13 percent of its home territory and all its overseas possessions, while German annexation of other states was prohibited, reparations were imposed, and limits were placed on the size and capability of the country's armed forces.^[17]

Germany and Italy

The German Empire was dissolved in the German revolution of 1918–1919, and a democratic government, later known as the Weimar Republic, was created. The interwar period saw strife between supporters of the new republic and hardline opponents on both the political right and left. Italy, as an Entente ally, had made some post-war territorial gains; however, Italian nationalists were angered that the promises made by the United Kingdom and France to secure Italian entrance into the war were not fulfilled in the peace settlement. From 1922 to 1925, the fascist movement led by Benito Mussolini seized power in Italy with a nationalist, totalitarian, and class collaborationist agenda that abolished representative democracy, repressed socialist, left-wing, and liberal forces, and pursued an aggressive expansionist foreign policy aimed at making Italy a world power, promising the creation of a "New Roman Empire".^[18]

Adolf Hitler, after an unsuccessful attempt to overthrow the German government in 1923, eventually became the chancellor of Germany in 1933 when President Paul von Hindenburg and the Reichstag appointed him. The Nazis soon abolished parliamentary democracy, espousing a radical, racially motivated revision of the world order, and began a massive rearmament campaign.^[19] Following Hindenburg's death in 1934, Hitler proclaimed himself *Führer* of Germany. France, seeking to secure its alliance with Italy, allowed Italy a free hand in Ethiopia, which Italy desired as a colonial possession. The situation was aggravated in early 1935 when the Territory of the Saar Basin was legally reunited with Germany, and Hitler repudiated the Treaty of Versailles, accelerated his rearmament programme, and introduced conscription.^[20]

European treaties

The United Kingdom, France and Italy formed the Stresa Front in April 1935 in order to contain Germany, a key step towards military globalisation; however, that June, the United Kingdom made an independent naval agreement with Germany, easing prior restrictions. The Soviet Union,



Adolf Hitler at a German Nazi political rally in Nuremberg, August 1933

concerned by Germany's goals of capturing vast areas of Eastern Europe, drafted a treaty of mutual assistance with France. Before taking effect, though, the Franco-Soviet pact was required to go through the bureaucracy of the League of Nations, which rendered it essentially toothless.^[21] The United States, concerned with events in Europe and Asia, passed the Neutrality Act in August of the same year.^[22]

Hitler defied the Versailles and Locarno Treaties by remilitarising the Rhineland in March 1936, encountering little opposition due to the policy of appeasement.^[23] In October 1936, Germany and Italy formed the Rome–Berlin Axis. A month later, Germany and Japan signed the Anti-Comintern Pact, which Italy joined the following year.^[24]

Asia

The Kuomintang party in China launched a unification campaign against regional warlords and nominally unified China in the mid-1920s, but was soon embroiled in a civil war against its former Chinese Communist Party (CCP) allies and new regional warlords.^[25] In 1931, an increasingly militaristic Empire of Japan, which had long sought influence in China as the first step of what its government saw as the country's right to rule Asia, staged the Mukden incident as a pretext to invade Manchuria and establish the puppet state of Manchukuo.^{[26][27]}

China appealed to the League of Nations to stop the Japanese invasion of Manchuria. Japan withdrew from the League of Nations after being condemned for its incursion into Manchuria. The two nations then fought several battles, in Shanghai, Rehe, and Hebei, until the Tanggu Truce was signed in 1933. Thereafter, Chinese volunteer forces continued the resistance to Japanese aggression in Manchuria, and Chahar and Suiyuan.^[28] After the 1936 Xi'an Incident, the Kuomintang and CCP forces agreed on a ceasefire to present a united front to oppose Japan.^[29]

Pre-war events

Italian invasion of Ethiopia (1935)

The Second Italo-Ethiopian War was a colonial war that began in October 1935 and ended in May 1936. The war began with the invasion of the Ethiopian Empire (also known as Abyssinia) by the armed forces of the Kingdom of Italy (*Regno d'Italia*), which was launched from Italian Somaliland and Eritrea.^[30] The war resulted in the military occupation of Ethiopia and its annexation into the newly created colony of Italian East Africa (*Africa Orientale Italiana*); in addition it exposed the weakness of the League of Nations as a force to preserve peace. Both Italy and Ethiopia were member nations, but the League did little when the former clearly violated Article X of the League's Covenant.^[31] The United Kingdom and France supported imposing sanctions on Italy for the

invasion, but the sanctions were not fully enforced and failed to end the Italian invasion.^[32] Italy subsequently dropped its objections to Germany's goal of absorbing Austria.^[33]

Spanish Civil War (1936–1939)

When civil war broke out in Spain, Hitler and Mussolini lent military support to the Nationalist rebels, led by General Francisco Franco. Italy supported the Nationalists to a greater extent than the Nazis: Mussolini sent more than 70,000 ground troops, 6,000 aviation personnel, and 720 aircraft to Spain.^[34] The Soviet Union supported the existing government of the Spanish Republic. More than 30,000 foreign volunteers, known as the International Brigades, also fought against the Nationalists. Both Germany and the Soviet Union used this proxy war as an opportunity to test in combat their most advanced weapons and tactics. The Nationalists won the civil war in April 1939; Franco, now dictator, remained officially neutral during World War II but generally favoured the Axis.^[35] His largest collaboration with Germany was the sending of volunteers to fight on the Eastern Front.^[36]



Benito Mussolini inspecting troops during the Italo-Ethiopian War, 1935

Japanese invasion of China (1937)

In July 1937, Japan captured the former Chinese imperial capital of Peking after instigating the Marco Polo Bridge incident, which culminated in the Japanese campaign to invade all of China following years of tension and low-level conflicts.^[37] The Soviets quickly signed a non-aggression pact with China to lend materiel support, effectively ending China's prior cooperation with Germany.^[38]

From September to November, the Japanese attacked Taiyuan, engaged the Kuomintang Army around Xinkou, fought Communist forces in Pingxingguan, Yang Kuisong, "On the reconstruction of the facts of the Battle of Pingxingguan" and wrestled control over China's northern railway network.^{[39][40][41]} Nationalist



Chinese soldiers battle the Imperial Japanese Army in Taierzhuang, 1938

Generalissimo Chiang Kai-shek deployed his best army to defend Shanghai, but after three months of heavy fighting, Shanghai fell. The Japanese continued to push Chinese forces back, capturing the capital Nanking in December 1937.^{[42][43][44]}

In March 1938, Nationalist Chinese forces won their first major victory at Taierzhuang, but ultimately lost control of the city of Xuzhou in May.^[45] In June 1938, Chinese forces stalled the Japanese advance by flooding the Yellow River; buying time for the Chinese to prepare their defences at Wuhan at heavy cost to the local civilian population, but the city was taken by October after heavy fighting along the Yangtze River.^[46]

Japanese military victories did not destroy Chinese resistance; instead, the Chinese government relocated inland to Chongqing and continued the war.^{[47][48]} Aiming to break Chinese morale, Japanese aircraft began striking cities in the Sichuan basin in a bombing campaign, killing tens of thousands of civilians.^{[49][50]}

Soviet–Japanese border conflicts

In the mid-to-late 1930s, Japanese forces in Manchukuo had sporadic border clashes with the Soviet Union and Mongolia. The Japanese doctrine of Hokushin-ron, which emphasised Japan's expansion northward, was favoured by the Imperial Army during this time. This policy would prove difficult to maintain in light of the Japanese defeat at Khalkin Gol in 1939, the ongoing Second Sino-Japanese War and ally Nazi Germany pursuing neutrality with the Soviets.^[51] Japan and the Soviet Union eventually signed a Neutrality Pact in April 1941, and Japan adopted the doctrine of Nanshin-ron, promoted by the Navy, which took its focus southward and eventually led to war with the United States and the Western Allies.^{[52][53]}

European occupations and agreements

In Europe, Germany and Italy were becoming more aggressive. In March 1938, Germany annexed Austria, again provoking little response from other European powers.^[54] Encouraged, Hitler began pressing German claims on the Sudetenland, an area of Czechoslovakia with a predominantly ethnic German population. Soon the United Kingdom and France followed the appeasement policy of British Prime Minister Neville Chamberlain and conceded this territory to Germany in the Munich Agreement, which was made against the wishes of the Czechoslovak government, in exchange for a promise of no further territorial demands.^[55] Soon afterwards, Germany and Italy forced Czechoslovakia to cede additional territory to Hungary, and Poland annexed the Trans-Olza region of Czechoslovakia.^[56]

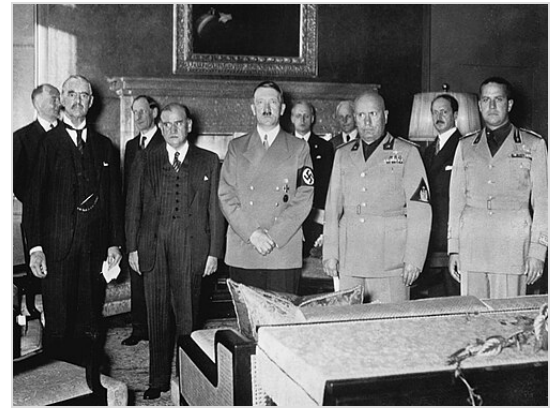
Although all of Germany's stated demands had been satisfied by the agreement, privately Hitler was furious that British interference had prevented him from seizing all of Czechoslovakia in one operation. In subsequent speeches Hitler attacked British and Jewish "war-mongers" and in

January 1939 secretly ordered a major build-up of the German navy to challenge British naval supremacy. In March 1939, Germany invaded the remainder of Czechoslovakia and subsequently split it into the German Protectorate of Bohemia and Moravia and a pro-German client state, the Slovak Republic.^[57] Hitler also delivered an ultimatum to Lithuania on 20 March 1939, forcing the concession of the Klaipėda Region, formerly the German Memelland.^[58]

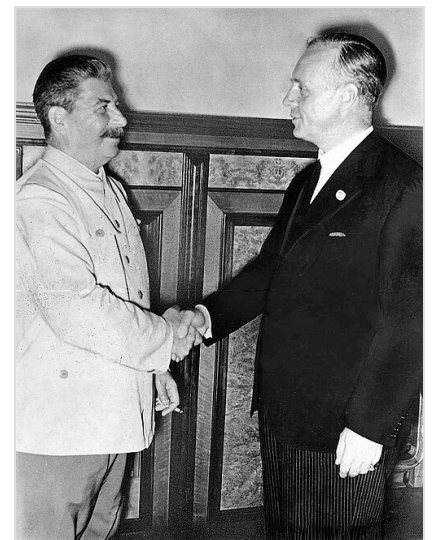
Following further demands from Hitler regarding the Free City of Danzig and the Polish corridor, the United Kingdom and France guaranteed their support for Polish independence. When Italy conquered Albania in April 1939, the same guarantee was extended to the Kingdoms of Romania and Greece.^[59] Shortly after the Franco-British pledge to Poland, Germany and Italy formalised their own alliance with the Pact of Steel.^[60] Hitler accused the United Kingdom and Poland of trying to encircle Germany and renounced the Anglo-German Naval Agreement and the German–Polish declaration of non-aggression.^[61]

The situation became a crisis in late August as Germany concentrated its forces near the Polish border. On 23 August, the Soviet Union signed a non-aggression pact with Germany, after tripartite negotiations for a military alliance between France, the United Kingdom, and Soviet Union had stalled.^{[62][63]} This pact had a secret protocol that defined German and Soviet spheres of influence: Lithuania for Germany; Finland, Estonia, Latvia and Bessarabia for the Soviet Union; and Poland to be partitioned between the two powers.^[64] The pact ensured that Germany would not face a war with the Soviet Union when it invaded Poland. Immediately afterwards, Hitler ordered the attack to proceed on 26 August, but upon hearing that the United Kingdom had concluded a formal mutual assistance pact with Poland and that Italy would maintain neutrality, he decided to delay it.^[65]

Germany offered Britain an alliance if Britain helped Germany gain Danzig, the Polish corridor and its former colonies, but Britain replied that it would honour its guarantee to Poland.^[66] On 29 August, Hitler demanded that a Polish plenipotentiary travel to Berlin by the following day to negotiate a solution to the crisis, but Britain rejected the timeline as unreasonable. On the night of 30–31 August, the British



From left to right: Chamberlain, Daladier, Hitler, Mussolini, and Ciano pictured just before signing the Munich Agreement, 29 September 1938



German Foreign Minister Joachim von Ribbentrop (right) and the Soviet leader Joseph Stalin after signing the Molotov–Ribbentrop Pact, 23 August 1939

ambassador Nevile Henderson met German Foreign Minister Joachim von Ribbentrop. Ribbentrop handed him Hitler's demands regarding Poland then announced that the deadline for Poland's acceptance had already passed.^[67]

Course of the war

War breaks out in Europe (1939–1940)

On 1 September 1939, Germany invaded Poland after having staged several false flag border incidents as a pretext to initiate the invasion.^[69] The first German attack of the war came against the Polish defences at Westerplatte.^[70] The United Kingdom responded with an ultimatum for Germany to cease military operations, and on 3 September, after the ultimatum was ignored, Britain and France declared war on Germany.^[c] During the Phoney War period, the alliance provided no direct military support to Poland, outside of a cautious French probe into the Saarland.^[71] The Western Allies also began a naval blockade of Germany, which aimed to damage the country's economy and war effort.^[72] Germany responded by ordering U-boat warfare against Allied merchant and warships, which would later escalate into the Battle of the Atlantic.^[73] On 8 September, German troops reached the suburbs of Warsaw. The Polish counter-offensive to the west halted the German advance for several days, but it was outflanked and encircled by the *Wehrmacht*. Remnants of the Polish army broke through to besieged Warsaw. On 17 September 1939, two days after signing a cease-fire with Japan, the Soviet Union invaded Poland^[74] under the supposed pretext that the Polish state had ceased to exist.^[75] On 27 September, the Warsaw garrison surrendered to the Germans, and the last large operational unit of the Polish Army surrendered on 6 October. Despite the military defeat, Poland never surrendered; instead, it formed the Polish government-in-exile and a clandestine state apparatus remained in occupied Poland.^[76] A significant part of Polish military personnel evacuated to Romania and Latvia; many of them later fought against the Axis in other theatres of the war.^[77]



A German propaganda photograph reenacting the removal of the Polish border crossing in Sopot.^[68]

Germany annexed western Poland and occupied central Poland; the Soviet Union annexed eastern Poland. Small shares of Polish territory were transferred to Lithuania and Slovakia. On 6 October, Hitler made a public peace overture to the United Kingdom and France but said that the future of Poland was to be determined exclusively by Germany and the Soviet Union. The proposal was rejected^[78] and Hitler ordered an immediate offensive against France,^[79] which was postponed until the spring of 1940 due to bad weather.^{[80][81][82]}

After the outbreak of war in Poland, Stalin threatened Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania with military invasion, forcing the three Baltic countries to sign pacts allowing the creation of Soviet military bases in these countries; in October 1939, significant Soviet military contingents were moved there.^{[83][84][85]} Finland refused to sign a similar pact and rejected ceding part of its territory to the Soviet Union. The Soviet Union invaded Finland in November 1939,^[86] and was subsequently expelled from the League of Nations for this crime of aggression.^[87] Despite overwhelming numerical superiority, Soviet military success during the Winter War was modest, and the Finno–Soviet war ended in March 1940 with some Finnish concessions of territory.^[88]



Mannerheim Line and Karelian Isthmus on the last day of the Winter War, 13 March 1940

In June 1940, the Soviet Union occupied the entire territories of Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania,^[84] as well as the Romanian regions of Bessarabia, Northern Bukovina, and the Hertsa region. In August 1940, Hitler imposed the Second Vienna Award on Romania which led to the transfer of Northern Transylvania to Hungary.^[89] In September 1940, Bulgaria demanded Southern Dobruja from Romania with German and Italian support, leading to the Treaty of Craiova.^[90] The loss of one-third of Romania's 1939 territory caused a coup against King Carol II, turning Romania into a fascist dictatorship under Marshal Ion Antonescu, with a course set towards the Axis in the hopes of a German guarantee.^[91] Meanwhile, German–Soviet political relations and economic co-operation^{[92][93]} gradually stalled,^{[94][95]} and both states began preparations for war.^[96]

Western Europe (1940–1941)

In April 1940, Germany invaded Denmark and Norway to protect shipments of iron ore from Sweden, which the Allies were attempting to cut off.^[97] Denmark capitulated after six hours, and despite Allied support, Norway was conquered within two months.^[98] British discontent over the Norwegian campaign led to the resignation of Prime Minister Neville Chamberlain, who was replaced by Winston Churchill on 10 May 1940.^[99]

On the same day, Germany launched an offensive against France. To circumvent the strong Maginot Line fortifications on the Franco-German border, Germany directed its attack at the neutral nations of Belgium, the Netherlands, and Luxembourg.^[100] The Germans carried out a flanking manoeuvre through the Ardennes region,^[101] which was mistakenly perceived by the Allies as an impenetrable natural barrier against armoured vehicles.^{[102][103]} By successfully implementing new *Blitzkrieg* tactics, the *Wehrmacht* rapidly advanced to the Channel and cut off the Allied forces in Belgium, trapping the bulk of the Allied armies in a cauldron on the Franco-